

A TWIST IN THE TALE

From a Princeton professor to a former Wall Street banker and a news cameraman with an affinity for troubled spots, a story-starved Bollywood is embracing new writers from varied backgrounds

■ By Kaverie Bamzai

One day, two and a half years ago, Anvita Dutt Guptan took a taxi from her home in Kalyan to her well-appointed office in Worli and her wonderful job as creative director of an advertising agency. She'd been there a year, her fourteenth in a career that had taken her from Everest to Trikaya Grey to O&M. She had a glittering future ahead. But she quit her job, hoping to live her dream of writing for Bollywood.

It's a dream other people are following, from a Princeton professor to a bestselling writer-cum-banker, from a former Wall Street mergers-and-acquisitions specialist to a former flight attendant-turned-stay-at-home-mom who learnt screenwriting by downloading free software from the Internet. And Bollywood, starved of original writing, is clasping these new converts to its bosom with the zeal it reserves for true blue stars. It has brought with it a new sensibility, of taking on headline-grabbing issues and of speaking in salt-of-the-earth language. Sometimes it's just a fresh take, free of rip-offs of DVDs borrowed from the most influential creative source in the Mumbai film industry, the Sarvodaya video library in Bandra, and remakes of blockbusters in Tamil and Telugu. It's allowing people from different professions to walk into big-name production houses and narrate stories to marquee filmmakers.

Take Jaydeep Sarkar. Till just about a year ago, he was just another writer, albeit with an impressive degree in philosophy from St Stephen's College, Delhi. Now, with the critical success of *Shaurya*, a winning adaptation of *A Few Good Men* set in Kashmir with a highly unflattering view of the Indian Army, he's getting calls from produc-

ers. "I keep wondering how they got my number," says Sarkar, 28, who has also written Goldie Behl's forthcoming *Drona*, and finds inspiration in Hindi and Bengali literature.

Inspiration is being sought even farther afield. As in a play Rohan Sippy was told of by a friend. Written by Anuvab Pal—a 32-year-old former Wall

▼ ANVITA DUTT GUPTAN, 36

BACHNA AE HASEENO

"I don't write for myself, three critics and 17 English-speaking viewers."



SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE

Street banker who moved to Mumbai from New York to work as head of business development for Thomson Reuters—the play impressed Sippy so much that he decided to produce Pal's work, *The President is Coming*, one of 12 new plays commissioned for The Rage Productions/Royal Court Theatre Writers Bloc festival in Mumbai. Shot in 23 days in Mumbai, directed by Kunaal Roy Kapoor and starring Konkona Sen Sharma along with Shernaz Patel, it

comes after Manish Acharya's *Loins of Punjab Presents*, which Pal co-wrote (and did a part in). It doesn't stop Pal from seeing irony all around him, whether it is calls from producers asking that he adapt a "gay theme set in a jail in New Mexico" to India, while also upping its "erotic content"; or maybe base a story in Uzbekistan while ensuring a scene with an Air France flight taking off and landing (for sponsorship reasons); or even write a scene around